In Maharashtra, our team had to take on additional responsibility in helping with the walking and afternoon interactions with Rahul Gandhi. The Mobile Secretariat from Delhi was allowed to join the Yatra, so they got a first-hand experience. Unlike previous states, in Maharashtra, we also had to work closely with senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh's team to facilitate walking interactions with Rahul Gandhi. We designated special spots along the route, where people would wait with one or two of us, and then walk them in up to the security cordon around Rahul Gandhi, where Jairam sir's team would take them in. Similarly, we had to facilitate the entry of civil society and community leaders into Camp 1 and the tent where Rahul Gandhi would interact with them. Maharashtra was a unique experience for all of us. Not only did we meet hundreds of important personalities from civil society, but we also learnt many of the state's problems. This kind of grassroots learning is important, especially for upcoming leaders.

In Jammu and Kashmir, on the other hand, unique challenges unfolded for us, because suddenly all mobile networks stopped functioning. We could no longer coordinate with civil society or the Delhi Secretariat. It was a logistical nightmare, and we were constantly worried about the civil society yatris under our care. Plus, the security problems we faced in other states were magnified manifold in Kashmir. It took repeated interventions by the then AICC general secretary Rajni Patil to overcome these challenges. We had to also acquire local SIM cards to re-establish basic communication. We were all wondering at how ordinary Kashmiris could manage like this, and all of us could see the stark difference between the Union government's propaganda about normalcy in Kashmir and the reality. Plus the constant propaganda spread about Kashmiris as being pro-Pakistan and anti-India had created suspicions in many minds. But the enthusiasm and love of the Kashmiri people who came out in the biting cold and snow to welcome us busted all those myths. They were there only as Indians, and welcomed all of us as their fellow citizens.